Story Writing

The big idea

In story writing you are given a **beginning** (or a few cues or a title) and must complete an interesting story of about **150–200 words**. Examiners look for a **clear plot**, believable **characters**, a **climax**, a satisfying **conclusion**, and correct language. Stories are usually written in the **past tense**.

Elements of a story

Element	What it means
Title	short, catchy, linked to the theme
Setting	time and place: "On a stormy night in Shimla..."
Characters	one or two main characters with names and traits
Plot	sequence of events: beginning → rising action → climax → resolution
Conflict	the problem or challenge the character faces
Climax	the most exciting or tense moment
Resolution/ending	how the problem is solved; may include a moral or twist

Steps to write a good story

1. **Read the given beginning carefully** and continue from it without changing names, tense or point of view.
2. **Plan quickly**: list 4–5 events and decide the ending before you start.

3. **Hook the reader**: use action, dialogue or suspense early.
4. **Build to a climax**: add tension, obstacles, feelings.
5. **End meaningfully**: a resolution, a lesson learnt, or a surprise twist (like "The Last Leaf").
6. **Give a title** if asked.

USE OF DIALOGUE

A few lines of dialogue make a story lively. Put spoken words in quotation marks and start a new line for each new speaker: "Who's there?" whispered Riya.

SAMPLE (BEGINNING GIVEN: "IT WAS THE LAST DAY OF THE SCHOOL TRIP...")

The Silver Bracelet

It was the last day of the school trip to Nainital. As we boarded the bus, Aman noticed a silver bracelet glittering near the hotel steps. "Finders keepers," joked Rohan. Aman hesitated. He remembered the old lady who had been searching her bag anxiously that morning.

Without wasting a minute, he ran back into the hotel, though the driver was honking impatiently. The receptionist helped him find the lady's room. Her eyes filled with tears when she saw the bracelet. "It was my late husband's last gift," she said, blessing him again and again.

Aman returned to the bus, panting, and the teacher frowned at the delay. But when she heard the reason, she announced it to the whole class, and everyone clapped. That evening Aman realised that honesty brings a joy far greater than any treasure.

Language tips

- Keep **past tense** consistent (past perfect for earlier events: "She had forgotten her key").
- Use **linkers**: suddenly, meanwhile, after a while, at last, to his surprise.

- Use **vivid verbs and adjectives**: dashed, whispered, trembling, deserted.
- Vary sentence length: short sentences create suspense.

COMMON MISTAKES

Changing the given beginning; too many characters; no climax; abrupt or "it was all a dream" endings; switching between past and present tense; exceeding the word limit.

MARKING SCHEME

Typically marks are for **content** (plot, creativity, relevance to cues), **organisation** (coherence, sequence) and **accuracy and fluency** (grammar, spelling, vocabulary). Leave 2 minutes to proofread for tense and spelling errors.

Practice

1. Complete: "As I opened the door of the old library, a strange sound came from the last shelf..."
2. Write a story using the cues: lost puppy – rainy evening – little girl – shelter – owner found – reward refused.
3. Write a story with the title "Presence of Mind" (150–200 words).

Quick recap

- Title, setting, characters, conflict, climax, resolution.
- Continue the given beginning; plan before writing.
- Past tense, dialogue, linkers, vivid words; meaningful ending within the word limit.

Practice questions

1. The most exciting or tense point in a story is called the
   (a) setting (b) resolution (c) climax (d) title
2. Stories are usually narrated in the
   (a) simple past tense (b) simple present tense (c) future tense (d) present perfect tense
3. When a story beginning is given, you should
   (a) change the character's name to your liking (b) continue it without changing names, tense or point of view (c) ignore it and write your own story (d) rewrite the beginning in your own words
4. Which of these is a good linker for story writing?
   (a) because of that reason why (b) moreover furthermore (c) in conclusion (d) suddenly
5. The time and place in which a story happens is its
   (a) plot (b) theme (c) setting (d) climax
6. Which ending is generally weakest in a board-exam story?
   (a) A surprise twist (b) A lesson learnt by the character (c) A problem solved by courage (d) "And then I woke up; it was all a dream"
7. Write a story in 150–200 words beginning with: "The power suddenly went off, and the house was plunged into darkness..."

Answers: 1. c 2. a 3. b 4. d 5. c 6. d 7. see notes